

#2 Valid Anagram

Arrays & Hashing

LeetCode 242

NeetCode "Valid Anagram"

PROBLEM

Given two strings *s* and *t*, return *true* if the two strings are anagrams of each other, otherwise return *false*. An anagram is a string that contains the exact same characters as another string, but the order of the characters can be different.

```
s = "racecar", t = "carrace" → true
```

```
s = "jar", t = "jam" → false
```

CORE IDEA

Goal

Determine whether two strings are anagrams of each other.

Key insight

Two strings are anagrams exactly when they contain the same characters the same number of times — order doesn't matter, so the problem reduces to comparing character frequency counts instead of comparing the strings directly.

Trigger: "Same letters, different order?" → reach for a character frequency count (Hash Map).

OPTIMAL SOLUTION

Data structure — Two Hash Maps (Python dict) tracking character counts

1. If *s* and *t* have different lengths, they can't be anagrams — return *False* immediately.
2. Walk both strings together in one pass, building *counterS* and *counterT* with `dict.get(char, 0) + 1`.
3. For every character in *counterS*, compare its count against *counterT.get(char, 0)*; any mismatch means the strings aren't anagrams — return *False*.
4. If every character's count matches, return *True*.

$O(n + m)$

TIME

$O(1)$

SPACE

CODE

```
class Solution:
    def isAnagram(self, s: str, t: str) -> bool:
        counterS, counterT = {}, {}
        if len(s) != len(t):
            return False

        for ch in range(len(s)):
            counterS[s[ch]] = 1 +
counterS.get(s[ch], 0)
            counterT[t[ch]] = 1 +
counterT.get(t[ch], 0)

        for c in counterS:
            if counterS[c] != counterT.get(c, 0):
                return False

        return True
```

TIPS TO REMEMBER

Mental shortcut — "Same letters, same counts → anagram."

Common / related — Group Anagrams, Two Sum, Contains Duplicate

"I'm comparing character frequency counts instead of sorting, which keeps this at $O(n)$ time instead of $O(n \log n)$ — and because the alphabet is fixed at 26 lowercase letters, the extra space is effectively $O(1)$."

EDGE CASES

- ▶ Different lengths → return *False* immediately, no counting needed
- ▶ *s* and *t* are identical strings → trivially anagrams
- ▶ All identical characters, e.g. "aaa" vs "aaa" → *true*
- ▶ Input is lowercase-only per constraints — mixed case or Unicode input would need normalizing first